

essay

UNEQUAL PARTNERS

WAKING UP IS HARD TO DO BUT IF THE URBAN INDIAN MAN DOESN'T WANT TO LOSE HIS WIFE, IT'S TIME HE DID. MARRIAGE SEEMS TO HAVE GIVEN HIM A LICENCE TO THRILL, EVEN AS IT SEEMS TO HAVE CAGED THE WOMAN'S SPIRIT.

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

They were young, educated, and both virgins on this, their wedding night, and they lived in a time when conversation about sexual difficulties was plainly difficult. But it is never easy.

an McEwan was writing about a couple in 1962 England in *On Chesil Beach* (he, er, arrives too soon in bed and she runs away in disgust), but he may well be speaking of thousands of contemporary marriages in India. The INDIA TODAY AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG Survey of Urban Marriage, the fifth in our series of sex studies, spotlights what goes on behind fluttering lace curtains, away from the glossy fantasies of warm satin sheets, cool rain-drenched greens and steam-filled showers.

Call it a byproduct of the growth in GDP or the result of social transformation, but the things that make life more fulfilling have also made it more open to cracks. If love is the triumph of imagination over intelligence, then the urban Indian marriage is the victory of opportunity over occasion. Greater infidelity on the part of men, increasing resistance of the woman to coercive sex, even the lessening appeal of the woman post-marriage are all indicative of a relationship under tremendous strain. The men and women are at odds with each other, not just in the act but also in attitude, creating an unequal partnership where there should be comfort-giving compatibility. While 52 per cent of the men say they have sex thrice a week, only 27 per cent of the women agree, a yawning

gap not explained entirely by the man's braggadocio. What's more, 39 per cent of the women are bored with sex in marriage, up from 8 per cent in the 2003 survey.

If the survey were to be distilled into a book, its title would be from the man's point of view: 'I'm OK, and You, Hey, Are You There?' The bedroom seems to be the man's preserve, his kingdom, his haven, while the woman seems to be at her *sati-savitri* suffering best. Almost 40 per cent of the married women said their partner's pleasure was more important than their own, which was almost a 30 per cent jump over the 2003 survey of what women want. Such timidity in the bedroom seems to have emboldened the man—over three-fourth of the men believe it is their marital right to have sex, again consistent with the

response in 2004. As for women professionals in nuclear families, they have it bad both ways, points out sociologist Shiv Visvanathan, lacking both the protection of the joint family and being subjected to husbands who seem to be distracted by the seductions of the city.

Family above individual and duty before pleasure, it is as if the sexual explicitness of an increasingly promiscuous society is passing the married women by—yes, they are conscious of the absence of it but unable to pursue gratification outside marriage (after all, 31 per cent of men admitted to infidelity while just 6 per cent women accepted it).

None of the traditional stereotypes seem to have changed, especially when it comes to men. More than half the men interviewed believe housewives have better married lives compared to working women, while 48 per cent of working women think that housewives won't necessarily have better mar-

**55% MEN PREFER THE MAN ON TOP POSITION
WHILE 19% LIKE THE WOMAN BEING ON TOP**